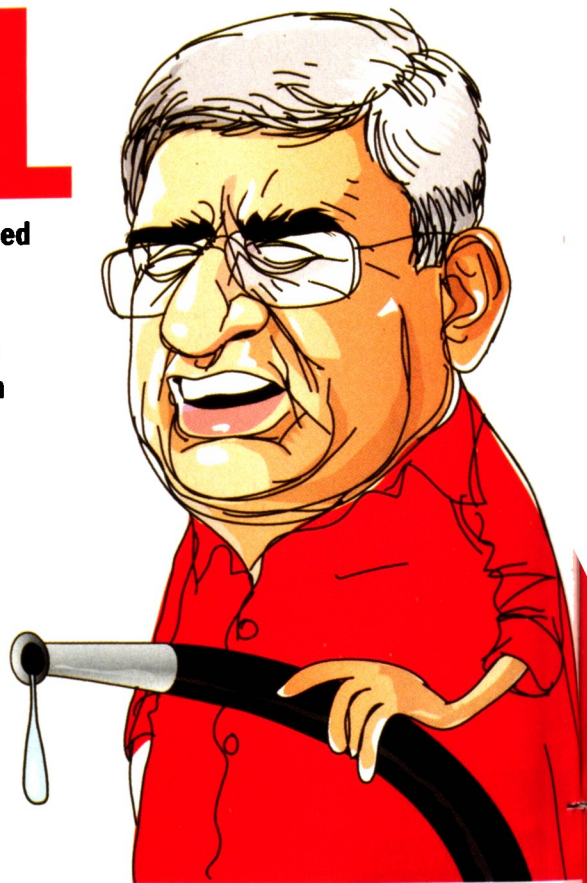


NO CLEAR DEAL

The Government is painted into a corner as the comrades refuse to give in. With the US deadline approaching, Manmohan has few options left.



SAURABH SINGH

■ By Priya Sahgal and Saurabh Shukla

It has now become a ritual. Before each meeting of the UPA-Left panel on the nuclear deal, come the great expectations and an equal amount of anxiety. There is the usual debate over the merits of the deal. There is a buzz that this time round, the Government will finally bite the bullet and sacrifice itself for the nuclear cause. And then comes the anticlimax. Nothing happens. Over the last nine months, there have been eight meetings of the 15-member panel over tea hosted by External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee. After over an hour of snacks and drafts, he comes out with a one-line statement: The panel has

met and decided to meet again.

This week was slightly different in that; the panel did not even bother with the pretence of a meeting. Hours before it was to meet on June 18, it postponed the meeting. This incidentally is the second postponement over a month. The excuse given was as lame as the committee: Mukherjee's engagements with visiting Syrian President Bashar al-Assad. Since the Syrian President did not sneak into the country taking the entire Ministry of External Affairs by surprise, few have bought this explanation. Especially when the date of Assad's visit was fixed much in advance with the approval of Mukherjee, who is also the chairperson of the panel.

Moreover, the entire country is all

too aware that it was not external affairs but the domestic agenda that has been keeping Mukherjee busy during the entire week. He has held two one-on-one meetings with the CPM leader, the obdurate Prakash Karat. Mukherjee tried to convince Karat to 'trust' the UPA but in vain. As a compromise, he asked Karat to allow the Government to at least sign the India specific safeguard agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). "We have taken you into confidence throughout. You will be taken into confidence in the future also," he told the Marxist leader.

As Karat later told the media, after this step the deal goes on 'auto-pilot' and the Left would lose its veto power. He is right. After the IAEA clearance, the deal will be put before the 45-member NSG to get an India-specific exemption to its guidelines, clearing the way for nuclear commerce between India and

"Left is of the firm opinion that the UPA should not proceed to seek IAEA approval." PRAKASH KARAT